mortgage crisis"—the lessons learned can actually help you successfully buy (and keep) your first home. But it may be much more challenging for you to qualify, so you'll need to be extremely well prepared.

Of course, if you're like most people starting out, you may be nowhere near the point where you can consider buying a home, so you can benefit from the next section of this chapter, which offers tips on being a smart renter. And you can get an idea of where you're headed and make your goals more concrete.

WHAT EVERY RENTER NEEDS TO KNOW

Even if you're not ready to buy, there are plenty of ways to reduce the cost of renting and eliminate the headaches you're likely to encounter as a tenant. A few strategies to consider:

- **Try to negotiate the rent.** I know a lot of people who feel squeamish about doing this, but you should force yourself. When you find a place you like, tell the landlord you're very interested but hadn't planned to spend as much as he or she is asking for. Ask in a superpolite way if there's any way you can get a break—say, paying $50 or $100 less a month or receiving one month free, depending on what the market is like where you live. If the landlord doesn't agree, nothing is lost. Of course, in cities where there are five renters competing for every apartment, your chances of getting a break are slim to none. So know your market. (You can also check out www.rentometer.com to get a rough idea of what people in that neighborhood are paying.) In some areas, the housing crisis has resulted in a huge supply of rentals. In others, the rental market is more competitive. You'll get a sense of how "hot" the market is by how quickly places get rented or how long they stay vacant. Knowing the details can help you get a better deal.
- **Negotiate the terms of your lease.** Though it isn't exciting, it's important that you carefully scrutinize your lease, which